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Phils Turn Prophets, Pick Braves to Win NL Pennant

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ST. LOUIS, July 30.—With one-third of the season left to be played, the National League pennant race looms as a three-team affair among the Pittsburgh Pirates, the Milwaukee Braves and the defending champion Los Angeles Dodgers. It could well turn out to be as close a finish as last year when the Dodgers beat the Braves in a playoff, while the San Francisco Giants, leaders for of the summer, faded to third.

Most of the experts expect the Braves to come through this time, although the Milwaukeeans haven't played up to their full potential for most of the campaign. The Phillies, who have had their least success against Milwaukee of the three top contenders, pick the Braves to take the flag this time.

An informal poll of the 25 players, three coaches and the manager turned up 21 votes for the Braves, four for the Pirates, and two for the Dodgers. Pitcher Robin Roberts declined to give an opinion, while Coach Andy Cohen predicted a tie between the Braves and Pirates.

Many of the Phils believe that the Dodgers, who recently shut them out three games in a row, are playing the best ball in the league right now, but feel that they started their move too late.

Manager Gene Mauch said, "I have to pick the Braves, but if they were all even in games right now I think the Dodgers would win it. But it's hard to say that they're enough better than the other two to make up the ground they have to."

"The Dodgers have exceptional pitching, and they have a good defense. They should be in every game they play, but the Braves have a lot of guys who can bust that ball right down through their sixth man in the order. Of course, their defense doesn't match the Dodgers."

The players who picked the Pirates included coach Ken Silvestri, center fielder Tony Gonzalez, first baseman Frank Herrera and shortstop Ruben Amaro.

"The Pirates have good balance," Silvestri said. "They have pitching, defense, a lot of good hitters and they're hungry. They've never played on a winner before."

The two players who picked the Dodgers were outfielder Lee Walls and catcher Cal Neeman.

"The Dodgers are rolling," Walls said, "and I think they can catch them. They weren't much better off a year ago and they won it then."

Neeman felt the Braves could win except for one thing. "I don't like Milwaukee's bullpen," he said. "If (Don) McMahon were pitching the way he used to, they would probably win, but he's having trouble, and they're having to rely on untried youngsters and some of their starters. That could ruin them."

Most of the Phils picked Milwaukee to win at this time last season, too, but the Dodgers surprised almost everyone. They could do it again.

Relief star Dick Farrell believes the Braves' bullpen problem is the only drawback the Tribe has. "If they get any help out there," Dick said, "they could run away with it."

Coach Peanuts Lowrey pointed to slugger Hank Aaron as a key man in the Braves' bid.

"You know he's going to finish up around .330," Lowrey said, "and he's been under .300 most of the last few months. When he starts hitting like he can and probably will, they're going to score a bunch of runs, and I think they'll win it."